

buy that house, we saved the down payment in two months (oh, what a time to be a homebuyer!). After two years of bare-minimum spending, I'd become what most people would consider a "saver." With no student loans and a fully funded emergency fund, I thought I was finally good at spending. But instead I found a new problem—hoarding money, saving aggressively, and denying myself the smallest things out of fear I'd need it once it's gone. I still felt like I wasn't doing enough, and I punished myself for wanting more and better. I realized that, even with more income and financial security, the guilt I felt about spending money was not the money's issue. It was mine. And no matter how much I had or how I saw myself financially, nothing would ever be enough. I'd never be able to spend enough or save enough to get what I wanted.

Now when I think of spending, I think of a piece of advice the world was blessed with in 1998 that's aged much better than other advice from the decade. It's from Andy "Brink" Brinker in the Disney Channel original movie *Brink!* In the final skating battle of the movie, he reminds his friends that while they all love skating, "Win or lose, skating is what we do. Not who we are."

We feel the same about spending.

We love the things money can buy us, but at the end of the day, spending is what we do, not who we are.

Our culture puts so much emphasis on what and how you buy to define who you are, but in truth your identity is not tied to what you spend or don't spend on. There is no such thing as being a "spender" or a "saver." Everyone spends, everyone saves. Spending is what we do, not who we are.

If our identities were tied to what we buy, what's the incentive to spend less? Why would we want to be less of who we are? Dinners out, gifts, and traveling the world are great things to spend your money on, but buying them doesn't define who you are or how capable you are with money. In the same vein, a fat bank account, loaded 401(k), and no debt are great, but they too are not the sum of your worth. You can be fun, generous, adventurous, and smart with or without those things.

And you are worthy of all the things you want in life. Not because of the things you buy or don't buy, not in spite of the things you buy or don't buy, but simply because you exist. Not being able to afford something doesn't mean you don't deserve it.